

# Plan it. Date it.

A good quarter plan turns a vague feeling into a number, a risk and a date. The same skill works on a slow month and on a customer who says "not this quarter."

## PRESENT YOUR QUARTER IN FIVE MOVES

- 1 Let me walk you through my Q4 plan** and start with the number.  
"I'm at 62% of quota with five weeks left. Here's where I need you."
- 2** Separate what is confirmed from what you hope: **commit** or **best case**?  
"It's best case for now. Legal hasn't signed off yet."
- 3 I want to flag one risk early.** Attach an action to every risk.  
"It's not in danger yet, but I'm watching it. I'll confirm the review date this week."
- 4** Name the pattern, then the play: **Q3 is typically soft for us, so I'm planning to...**  
"...reach out to 20 dormant accounts this month and book renewal talks early."
- 5** Ask for support, with a date: **Where I could use your help is...**  
"...the call with their CFO. Could you join on the 14th?"

## TOO BLUNT → SAY THIS

|                                        |                                                                                 |
|----------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <del>Just checking in.</del>           | <b>Last time you mentioned the Q1 launch. I thought this might help.</b>        |
| <del>Are you the decision maker?</del> | <b>How would your organization make a decision like this?</b>                   |
| <del>I'll circle back. No rush.</del>  | <b>Does the week of the 14th work for a 20-minute check-in?</b>                 |
| <del>Is this a no?</del>               | <b>Is it a timing issue, or is something in the proposal not sitting right?</b> |
| <del>This offer ends today.</del>      | <b>I can hold this price until the 30th. No pressure.</b>                       |
| <del>You need to decide.</del>         | <b>What would make this an easier decision?</b>                                 |

### Commit is a promise.

It's your public call, not a guess. Say it only with evidence.

### Pipeline, not funnel.

Deals in progress are your pipeline.

### Fall, not autumn.

And "slow season" or "off-peak" sounds more natural than "low season."

### Hedge on purpose.

My read is... / I'm not seeing X yet / so far / at this point.

## WHEN THE CUSTOMER SAYS "LET'S TALK NEXT QUARTER"

- 1. Accept, then ask what changes**  
| "Understood, and thanks for being upfront. What changes between now and then?"  
| Concrete answer ("budget resets in January") = real pipeline. Vague answer = probably a soft no.
- 2. Make the cost of waiting visible, gently**  
| "I'm not trying to rush you. I just want us to weigh what waiting would cost."
- 3. Turn "next quarter" into a week**  
| "Could we get 20 minutes with legal in the next two weeks? I'll check in the week of January 12."
- 4. Lower the risk**  
| "We can start small with a pilot, so there's less risk on your side."
- 5. Stay in touch without pestering**  
| "Would you be open to me sending one useful resource in the meantime? No pitch."

## WHEN YOUR MANAGER CHALLENGES YOU

**Manager:** "Is Acme really a commit, or are we hoping legal moves faster?"

**Rep:** "Fair question. The economic buyer confirmed budget, but legal hasn't started. I'll move it to best case until I have a review date."

**Manager:** "Isn't that just an excuse?" (about a seasonal dip)

**Rep:** "I hear you. That's why I'm not waiting for leads. What would you want to see from me to feel comfortable with the plan?"

# Read the quarter.

Quarter end is a signal for you and leverage for the buyer. Know how the other side reads it before you walk into the room.

THE FORECAST LADDER

| Pipeline                    | Best case                        | Commit              | Closed |
|-----------------------------|----------------------------------|---------------------|--------|
| Early stage, low confidence | Good signals, open contingencies | Your public promise | Signed |

Pipeline coverage = qualified pipeline ÷ target    3x is the common baseline; most B2B teams aim for 3x to 5x

If your win rate is 25%, you need about 4x. Weighted coverage is more honest than unweighted. A deal that slips once can stay; after a second push, take it out of commit.

WHAT THE MANAGER ASKS

- "What would have to be true for this to close this quarter?"
- "Is the close date yours or theirs?"
- "Has legal, security or procurement started?"
- "What's the next step, and is it on the calendar?"
- "Who is the economic buyer?" (the person with authority to approve)

WHAT THE BUYER SAYS

- "We can sign by the 30th if the price reflects the volume."
- "We have a competing quote, so I need you to sharpen your number."
- "Procurement needs to review this first, so I can't commit to a date."
- "That's outside our budget this year." (budget freeze)

TOOL: THE MUTUAL ACTION PLAN

A shared list of steps, **owners** and **dates**, for both sides. It turns "we'll see" into a calendar.

"Let's put together a short plan with owners and dates on both sides. Who else should be in the loop?"

SALES-FLOOR TALK: CAN YOU SAY IT OUT LOUD?

| EXPRESSION                                                                                              | MEANING                                    | AT WORK, SAY                                  |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
|  <b>commit</b>       | Deal you promise to close                  | "I'm committing this deal."                   |
|  <b>sandbagging</b>  | Hiding deal potential to look better later | "I'm being conservative on timing."           |
|  <b>happy ears</b>   | Hearing what you want to hear              | "I don't have written confirmation yet."      |
|  <b>kick the can</b> | Keep pushing a decision later              | "We're moving the decision to March."         |
|  <b>go dark</b>      | A customer stops answering                 | "We haven't heard back since the demo."       |
|  <b>pipe gen</b>     | Prospecting time for new pipeline          | "I'm blocking Tuesday mornings for pipe gen." |

Blue thumb: fine in a meeting. Pink thumb: common among colleagues, but not what you say about yourself or to a customer.

LOW SEASON, ON THE PAGE

| CHUNK                         | IN A SENTENCE                                                          |
|-------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>seasonal dip</b>           | "This is a seasonal dip, not a trend. Same pattern as last year."      |
| <b>dormant accounts</b>       | "I'm re-engaging dormant accounts from the last 12 months."            |
| <b>replenish the pipeline</b> | "I want to replenish the pipeline before the fall rush."               |
| <b>use-it-or-lose-it</b>      | "They have use-it-or-lose-it money, so the window closes November 30." |
| <b>trade, don't give</b>      | "I can move on price if we move to a two-year term."                   |

WATCH OUT: FALSE FRIENDS

|                        |                                                                                                    |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>eventually</b>      | Does not mean "eventualmente". It means "in the end". Say <b>possibly</b> or <b>occasionally</b> . |
| <b>actually</b>        | Does not mean "atualmente". Say <b>currently</b> .                                                 |
| <b>pretend</b>         | Does not mean "pretender". Say <b>intend</b> or <b>plan</b> .                                      |
| <b>attend a client</b> | Does not mean "atender". Say <b>serve</b> or <b>help</b> .                                         |

Terms and ideas from Outreach, Salesloft, Challenger, HubSpot and Sandler. The sample sentences are standard usage written for this lesson.